

USATODAY.com, September 6, 2005

PCs Could Make In-dash Splash

"MAYBE YOU WERE PLANNING to buy an SUV the size of Liechtenstein," asks Kevin Maney. But with a tank of fuel now costing as much as a ranch home, splurging on such a vehicle seems tacky. And stupid. And not cool. So he says!

If this keeps up, owning a big honkin' SUV will be about as hip as owning music on cassette tapes.

So what can you do if you want to dance on the leading edge of automotive style?

Why, you can geek your ride.

In other words, you can put a butt-whuppin' PC in your car with a touch-screen panel in the dashboard, Wi-Fi antenna, iTunes pumping music through speakers, Global Positioning System (GPS) tracking, video games, e-mail and technology that can both keep your attention on the road and help you sue anyone who rear-ends you.

Most of the PCs going into cars are Microsoft Windows-based, which prompts jokes that burble around the Internet. Like: If the air bag is about to go off, will it first say, "Are you sure?"

Companies have been trying to popularize car PCs for years, but the gadgets have never really taken off.

That seems to be changing as hobbyists pour into the market. Two recent books are pulling in newcomers. One, *Car PC Hacks*, is by Damien Stolarz, who's been outfitting cars with computers since 1998. The other, *Geek My Ride*, has a foreword by Apple

Computer co-founder Steve Wozniak.

Entrepreneurs have been launching car computer start-ups. Big tech companies such as Microsoft, Intel and IBM show off prototypes at auto shows. And carmakers, especially General Motors, say next-generation cars will come loaded with this stuff.

Says a Forrester Research report: "Just as the hot rodders of the 1950s begat Detroit's muscle cars of the 1960s, today's telematics hackers portend the future of telematics innovation."

By the way, what corporate goober decided that the industry should use "telematics" to describe putting computers linked to wireless communications into cars? Hackers wouldn't be caught dead calling their handiwork telematics.

The word's origin is telematique, which the French used to describe their Minitel-based pseudo-Internet in the 1970s. But now it just sounds like a made-up word you'd hear in a ThighMaster infomercial: "We used advanced telematics to determine the exact force needed to shape your thigh muscles ..."

Anyway, a number of factors seem to be coming together to give car PCs a boost. "One is that the computers are cheap enough now," author Stolarz says. "But, more importantly, the market is educated enough."

Rear-seat DVD players, MP3 players, satellite radio, GPS navigation systems—little by little, these devices have invaded cars and made people aware of the value of digital electronics in a moving vehicle. Car PCs are the next step—a single machine that can handle all of a car's entertainment, information and communication, but also enable capabilities few people even dreamed of a decade ago.

One example: mobile e-mail. Stolarz built a car PC with Wi-Fi. He can stop in front of a Starbucks that has Wi-Fi, connect, and download all his e-mail. He then touches a button on the screen in his dash and has a British-sounding voice synthesizer read his e-mail aloud as he drives.

For the complete column, go to: <http://snipurl.com/digitmw1>

PCMag.com, September 2005

Web Publishing Still Unsettled

BLOGGING IS WHAT Serious Personal Audio (<http://spa.machrone.net>), owner Bill Machrone is contemplating. Even after his blog was up and running he discovered that using blogging software as a bargain-basement Content Management System has its pitfalls

Blogging tools expect you to update often and can't grasp the concept that you'd like to control the articles on the main page independently of the date. But that's exactly what you'd want to do if you were publishing a site for a club or an organization—or if you just want to leave a welcome message up.

Movable Type, the software I chose, has a plug-in that allows you to keep items fixed on the page, but I haven't had a chance to install it yet. Ideally, I'd like an expansion field in the article database for an article number, and logic in the main page code that would sort the main page based on that number.

Right now, my brain-dead hack is simply to push

the article dates far into the future, so they don't archive off at the end of the month. I can change the sort order by changing the dates, but that changes the permalink, or article URL, which is bad if others are linking to my articles. I can also change the code to make the article date invisible, and then add a nonsorting date at the top.

I've received lots of mail from readers urging me (and PC Magazine) to explore this content-management-system-on-the-cheap route. And others who already use blogging software creatively have sent notes of encouragement, plus useful links.

Adrian Bacon, who runs Apple Log, Linux Log, and Microsoft Log, as well as his own site, said I should take a look at WordPress (WP), the free blogging tool offered by my ISP. He runs four WP blogs, although all seem to use the standard template. I'm going to try it, although I don't really like the stock look. I'll also investigate replacement templates.

I found several sites with downloadable WP themes and hacks, such as www.alexking.org, as well as an ambitious generator that builds a two- or three-column layout based on fields that you complete: www.erisfree.com/d2/apart.php. You can find these and other WP resources at <http://wordpress.org>.

A couple of readers strongly recommended Expression Engine (www.pmachine.com/ee). Their fervor alone is enough to get it on to my to-look-at list. Another reader said that b2, the ancestral code of WordPress, is alive and growing again at www.b2evolution.net.

If you need a real content management system, check out www.opensourcecms.com. This site has user ratings on many systems, and lets you test-drive most of them. The site also covers blog software, forums, groupware, and more.

For the complete column, go to: <http://snipurl.com/digitmw2>

